



Chen the knight

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Sony VAIO Tap 20

Tries to walk the line between a desktop and a tablet

It's great to see all-in-one desktops finally come packed with built-in batteries. And looking at the Sony VAIO Tap 20, it's unlike any other all-in-one desktop PC we've seen in the past year or so, making us wonder: is it a desktop or a tablet?

Sony traditionally makes well-designed products that look good, and it's the same story with this desktop tablet hybrid. The 20-inch wide frame of the Sony VAIO Tap 20 is built well, with a thin bezel and nice finish that oozes quality and style all around. The body is predominantly of high-grade plastic, with a foldable metal stand that props the unit up like a photo frame. Its two-toned black and white finish looks great, and when viewed from the front the Sony VAIO Tap 20 AIO resembles a giant Windows 8 tablet.

Having said that, there's no doubt that the Sony VAIO Tap 20 is a bit too heavy to be used as a tablet constantly while you're slouched on a sofa. Not only is it too heavy at 5 kg, it's also too big in terms of form factor, which isn't readily portable.

The 10 finger multitouch screen is quite responsive, especially during simultaneous multi-user interactions, and there's no navigational nag to talk about. Despite not being an IPS display, the Sony VAIO Tap 20 all-in-one desktop tablet hybrid's screen viewing angles are pretty good, with little or no colour shift. However, its screen does attract fingerprint smudges very easily, which is a constant nuisance. The built-in NFC capability of this device is also something unique to the VAIO Tap 20 -- this is the first NFC enabled AIO desktop tablet hybrid we've witnessed.

The Sony VAIO Tap 20 isn't an extraordinary all-in-one desktop or tablet hybrid, when it comes to hardware features. It has no optical drive, which is a bit of a shame considering its desktop DNA, but not a big concern if you don't deal much with optical media. The machine handles regular PC-related work, like surfing the Web, working on productivity tools, listening to music, etc., quite well and multitasks efficiently despite its ULV processor and average RAM offering.

The bundled wireless keyboard and mouse connect effortlessly with the Sony VAIO Tap 20 and work well overall. The keyboard has chiclet-styled keys that are nice to type on, and there's no lag whatsoever. The mouse, however, has an odd shape, and can take some time getting used to in terms of gripping it properly. In terms of its multimedia potential, watching movies and videos was a pleasant experience.



The desktop tablet hybrid's onboard stereo speakers, which come equipped with a subwoofer (situated at the top on the back panel), are quite pleasant to listen to. They aren't loud enough to fill a large room, but adequate for personal entertainment, with largely distortion-free audio even at high volume levels. Don't even think of gaming on the Sony VAIO Tap 20, as it only comes fitted with Intel HD 4000 graphics. Why Sony wouldn't include a high-speed SSD in this device (which sells at 70k) is something that bewilders us as much as the VAIO Tap 20's potential customers -- this is simply inexcusable on Sony's part.

The built-in battery of the Sony VAIO Tap 20 isn't much to talk about either. Because of its large screen, which is the number one reason behind battery drain, the AIO tablet hybrid barely lasts the full length of 2 hours, just enough to let you watch a Hollywood flick, we reckon. This is nowhere close to the performance you get on a laptop, ultrabook or a 10-inch tablet, for instance.

As an idea this Sony desktop-tablet hybrid isn't without its merits, but it's still far from perfection. If you always dreamt of buying a stylish, space-saving all-in-one desktop with a built-in battery, the Sony VAIO Tap 20 is worth looking into. It has great looks and design, decent hardware that performs well, and offers good multimedia potential. However, it's rather large for a tablet when it comes to personal use, and is quite cumbersome to move around for that reason.

Jayesh Shinde



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Specifications

Screen: 20-inch, 1600x900 pixel; **Touch input:** Multitouch enabled, 10 finger simultaneous; **CPU:** Intel Core i5-3337U; **CPU Speed:** 1.8 GHz; **RAM:** 4GB DDR3 1600MHz; **GPU:** Intel HD 4000; **HDD:** 500 GB, 5400 rpm; **OS:** 64-bit Windows 8; **Ports:** 2 x USB 3.0, SD Card slot, Headphone, Mic, Ethernet jack; **Wireless:** Wi-Fi 802.11 b/g/n, Bluetooth 4.0; **Webcam:** Built-in, 1.3 MP; **Keyboard:** Wireless; **Mouse:** Wireless; **Weight:** 5.2 kg; **Warranty:** 1 year

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